

Dot Voting

Fast, democratic convergence on the strongest ideas

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Dot voting (dotmocracy) is a simple prioritisation technique: each participant is given a fixed number of adhesive dots (or marks) and places them on the options they most support. The distribution of dots gives a quick, visible read of collective preference.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

A facilitation staple with no single inventor; formalised within participatory-design and 'Gamestorming' practice (Gray, Brown and Macanufo, 2010).

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Groups need a fast, low-conflict way to move from many ideas to a shortlist without lengthy debate or the loudest voice deciding.

FIGURE 1 · PROCESS VIEW

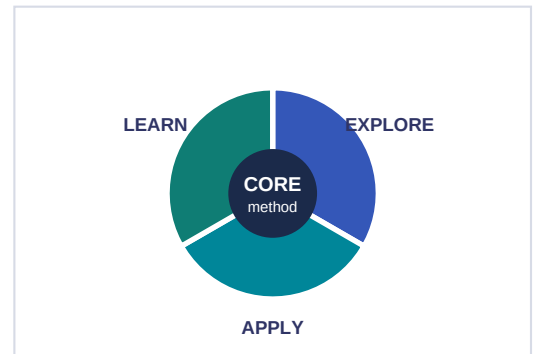


Figure 1. Dot Voting framed as a continuous, iterative method — explore, apply and learn cycle back through the work rather than run once.

HOW IT IS USED

Post all options visibly, give each person N dots, allow (or forbid) stacking dots on one option, then count. High-dot items advance; the pattern also reveals splits and dark-horse ideas.

WHEN IT IS USED

Immediately after a divergent phase, to converge on which ideas to prototype or discuss further.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Facilitators, workshop participants and teams of any kind making group choices.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It makes convergence **visible and egalitarian** in minutes, replacing slow discussion or top-down selection — a natural partner to divergent tools like brainwriting.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

6-3-5 Brainwriting *Slibrary 2*

2x2 Matrix *Slibrary 7*

Six Thinking Hats *Slibrary 2*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Gray, D., Brown, S. and Macanufo, J. (2010) *Gamestorming*. Sebastopol, CA: O'Reilly.

Osborn, A.F. (1953) *Applied Imagination*. New York: Scribner.